

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Do you have it in you?" For years, the world's second largest army has posed this question to youth between 18 and 25 years of age. Over the past decade, the response has been getting feebler, with training institutes reporting an intake of less than 10 per cent of their capacity, but alarm bells started ringing when just 190 cadets signed up this year for the three-year course offered by the National Defence Academy (NDA), Khadakvasla—the cradle of military training that produces the best army men—against a strength of 300 seats. Only 86 recruits, or just 34 per cent of the 250-strong allotted strength of the Indian Military Academy (IMA), Dehra Dun, turned up to become gentlemen cadets in the year-long course which commissions them into the army. The fact that such a large

The army presses the panic button as the number of cadets sinks to a historic low. Is paying more the answer?



THE MISSING OFFICERS

percentage of candidates—who went through a week-long selection process involving difficult physical and psychological tests that call for at least six months' preparation—did not "value the President's commission", is worrying, says an army official.

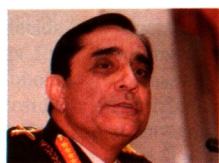
Almost 90 years after the British first threw the door open to Indian officers (the pre-1919 army was entirely British) and made a King's commission the ultimate goal for the aspiring youth of the previous century, the wheel has turned full circle. It is not that today's youth don't have it in them, but that they have other options. Last year, the then army chief General

J.J. Singh told INDIA TODAY, "We don't have a problem. There are lots of young men who want to join the army, the academy seats are always full." The cat, though, was let out of the bag when his successor General Deepak Kapoor recently warned that if the situation continues, the Government may have to consider compulsory military service: "We are not at that stage yet, but should the need arise, the Government may have to think about it."

The army chief's words may bring to mind images of bawling teenagers being dragged away from their parents to render compulsory military service à la Israel, but military analysts say such

a situation is neither feasible nor desirable in the Indian context. The Indian Army has always been a force of volunteers, even at the height of the 1962 war, which was termed as a grave external emergency. The warning was clearly aimed at the Sixth Central Pay Commission, which will submit its recommendations to the Government in April. The army has already asked that the pay of officers be doubled. "The implication is that if the Government does not hike pay substantially, the armed forces will have no option but to suggest politically unpopular moves like conscription," says an official. Doubling salaries, the army says, requires a three-per cent jump in its budget for allowances to officers, which constitutes nine per cent of its total budget for pay and allowances.

Last year, apart from a vigorous media campaign, Defence Minister A.K. Antony had announced a number



Should the need arise, conscription is something the Government may have to think about.

GENERAL DEEPAK KAPOOR, ARMY CHIEF